2.1 ELECTRIC CURRENT

Matter is made up of atoms. Each atom consists of a positively charged nucleus with negatively charged electrons moving around the nucleus. Atoms in metals have one or more electrons which are loosely bound to the nucleus. These electrons are called free electrons and can be easily detached from the atoms. The substances which have an abundance of these free electrons are called conductors. These free electrons move at random throughout the conductor at a given temperature. In general due to this random motion, there is no net transfer of charges from one end of the conductor to other end and hence no current. When a potential difference is applied by the battery across the ends of the conductor, the free electrons drift towards the positive terminal of the battery, producing a net electric current. This is easily understandable from the analogy given in the Figure 2.1.

In the XI Volume 2, unit 6, we studied, that the mass move from higher gravitational potential to lower gravitational potential. Likewise, positive charge flows from higher electric potential to lower electric potential and negative charge flows from lower electric potential to higher electric potential. So battery or electric cell simply creates potential difference across the conductor.

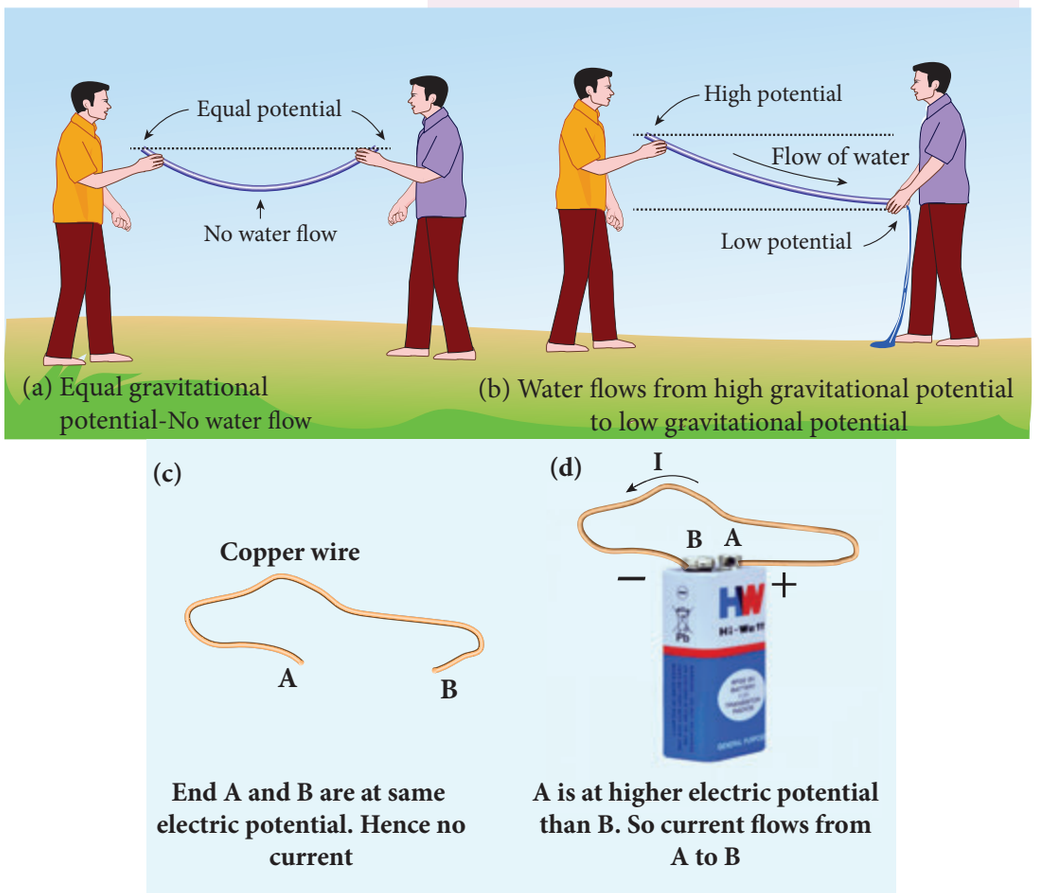


Figure 2.1 Water current and Electric current

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